Harbour City Council

Congestion Charge Consultation Proposal

A fictional policy document written for The Social World's sample world.

Prepared by the Harbour City Transport Committee - October 2026

Status: consultation draft - 12-week public consultation

This document is not a real government proposal. All places, numbers and names are invented so that a simulated population can debate a concrete policy.

1. Executive summary

Harbour City proposes a weekday congestion charge of GBP 6 for private vehicles entering the central zone between 07:00 and 19:00, Monday to Friday.

The council expects the charge to cut central traffic by 18% within 18 months, raise GBP 180 million gross each year and reduce nitrogen dioxide at the nine worst monitoring stations. After GBP 32 million of operating costs, GBP 148 million would be reinvested in public transport, walking and road safety.

Residents inside the zone would receive a 90% discount. Blue Badge holders, emergency vehicles and motorcycles would be exempt. Delivery vans would be exempt until 2028. Low-income households would receive a 40% discount.

The committee recommends a 24-month pilot with a formal review after 12 months.

2. The problem

Central Harbour City carries 62,000 vehicle entries on an average weekday. Average traffic speed in the zone has fallen from 18.4 km/h in 2015 to 14.2 km/h in 2026.

Drivers lose an estimated 38 minutes per weekday to congestion. Bus passengers lose 41 minutes on the three busiest corridors.

Nitrogen dioxide exceeds World Health Organization guideline levels at 9 of the 12 monitoring stations in the zone. The council's health assessment attributes 210 premature deaths a year to traffic-related air pollution.

Road collisions injure 340 people a year in the central zone, including 62 pedestrians and 28 cyclists. Traffic is the largest single source of the city's transport emissions.

3. How the charge would work

The zone covers 7.8 square kilometres between the river, the ring road and the university quarter. 142 automatic number-plate cameras would enforce it at 46 entry points.

The charge is GBP 6 per private vehicle per day, charged once for unlimited entries. Payment is due by midnight the next day. A GBP 12 penalty applies after 14 days.

Exemptions: Blue Badge holders, emergency vehicles, motorcycles, buses and coaches, and vehicles with zero tailpipe emissions registered before 2024.

Residents inside the zone pay 60p a day (90% discount). Low-income households receive a further 40% discount. Delivery vans are exempt until 1 January 2028.

The council estimates that 78% of drivers would pay through an app or automatic account. Payment terminals would be available at 22 libraries and community centres.

4. Where the money would go

Gross revenue: GBP 180 million a year. Operating costs: GBP 32 million (enforcement, IT, customer service, appeals). Net revenue: GBP 148 million.

Allocation: 45% (GBP 66.6m) to bus frequency and fares; 25% (GBP 37m) to cycling and walking; 20% (GBP 29.6m) to road safety and school streets; 10% (GBP 14.8m) to administration and monitoring.

The bus programme would add 14 vehicles on four routes, cut the Harbour Loop headway from 12 to 8 minutes and cap fares for under-25s at GBP 1.20. The council projects a 12% improvement in average bus journey times.

A ring-fenced reserve of GBP 8 million would cover revenue shortfalls in the first two years.

5. What the evidence says

The council reviewed 14 congestion-charge schemes. The median reduction in central traffic was 15%, with a range from 6% to 28%. London reported a 15% reduction after introduction; Stockholm reported 20%; Singapore's electronic scheme reported 10% in its first year.

Evidence on air quality is mixed but positive: NO2 fell by 8-12% in most schemes, while traffic displaced to boundary roads rose by 3-7%. The council's model projects a 9% reduction in NO2 inside the zone and a 4% increase on the outer ring.

Retail studies find no consistent effect on city-centre sales. Three of five studies found no measurable change; one found a 2% fall in the first year; one found a 4% rise after reinvestment in public space.

The evidence base is weaker for small cities under 500,000 people. Harbour City has 410,000 residents, so results may differ from London or Stockholm.

6. Business impact

The zone contains 7,800 registered businesses. A council survey of 620 businesses found 23% support, 41% opposition and 36% undecided.

Delivery companies estimate an extra GBP 4.50 per vehicle per day in charges. The proposed van exemption until 2028 is intended to give logistics firms time to consolidate deliveries and switch to electric vehicles.

Retailers on the high street are divided. Supporters point to fewer delivery conflicts and faster bus access; opponents fear that customers from outside the zone will shop elsewhere.

The council would create a GBP 6 million business transition fund for independent shops, covering electric cargo bikes, shared delivery hubs and shopfront improvements.

7. Equity and accessibility

18% of Harbour City households do not own a car. 9% of residents report a disability that affects travel. 31% of households earn below the city's living-wage threshold.

The 90% resident discount and 40% low-income discount are designed so that no household pays more than 60p a day to drive inside its own neighbourhood. Blue Badge holders are exempt entirely.

The consultation would include six public meetings, two online sessions, a paper response form and translated materials in the city's five most-spoken languages. Community groups would receive GBP 1,500 each to host their own discussions.

The committee acknowledges that charges are regressive unless revenue is returned to transport services used by people who do not drive. The bus and walking allocations are intended to do that, but the council would monitor distributional effects annually.

8. Environment

The council projects a reduction of 42,000 tonnes of CO2 a year, equivalent to taking 9,000 cars off the road. NO2 inside the zone would fall by an estimated 9%; PM2.5 by 6%.

Traffic noise at the busiest boundary streets is projected to fall by 3 decibels, which is roughly a halving of perceived loudness. Displacement to the ring road would raise noise there by 1 decibel.

Zero-emission vehicles registered before 2024 are exempt. The council would review the exemption in 2029 as the fleet electrifies, because the charge is intended to reduce traffic, not only emissions.

Green space is not directly affected, but the walking programme would add 6 kilometres of segregated paths and 14 new crossings near schools.

9. Implementation and enforcement

Timeline: detailed design (3 months), procurement (4 months), camera installation (6 months), public information campaign (3 months), go-live in month 18.

Costs: cameras and signs GBP 31 million; IT and payment platform GBP 24 million; customer service and appeals GBP 8 million a year; monitoring and evaluation GBP 2 million a year.

Enforcement would be based on number-plate recognition. The council would publish an annual report on accuracy, appeals and data protection. Images would be deleted after 90 days unless needed for an appeal.

The council would run a 24-month pilot. A formal review at 12 months would examine traffic, air quality, bus journeys, business impact and equity. The scheme could be amended or stopped after the review.

10. Consultation questions

1. Do you support a GBP 6 weekday charge for private vehicles entering the central zone?

2. Are the proposed exemptions and discounts fair? Which groups are missing?

3. How should the GBP 148 million net revenue be divided between buses, cycling, walking and road safety?

4. What would make the scheme work better for businesses, residents and disabled people?

5. Should the council proceed with a 24-month pilot, delay, or reject the proposal?

The consultation closes on 15 January 2027. Responses can be submitted online, by post or at any of the six public meetings.

11. Recommendation and risks

The Transport Committee recommends approving a 24-month pilot, subject to the consultation and a final vote by the full council.

Legal challenge: 20% likelihood, medium impact. Mitigation: publish the legal opinion and consultation record before the vote.

Revenue shortfall: 15% likelihood, medium impact. Mitigation: the GBP 8 million reserve and a mid-year review.

Traffic displacement: 8% likelihood, high impact on boundary wards. Mitigation: boundary bus priority, school streets and a ring-road monitoring programme.

Business opposition: high likelihood, medium impact. Mitigation: the transition fund, the 2028 van exemption and quarterly business forums.

Public legitimacy: the scheme depends on a transparent consultation and visible reinvestment. The committee recommends publishing a dashboard of traffic, air quality and spending every quarter.

12. About this document

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